

LifeBook

Customer Discovery Interview Guide

Version 1.2 · Step 2: Customer Discovery
Confidential — Internal Use Only

This is not a sales meeting. This is not product validation. This is an opportunity to discover what is real.

PURPOSE

The purpose of these interviews is to understand how people currently preserve, organize, revisit, and share the important moments of their lives.

We are here to discover:

- ▶ Real behaviours
- ▶ Real frustrations
- ▶ Real workarounds
- ▶ Real emotional triggers
- ▶ Real opportunities

The interviewer should avoid explaining LifeBook or suggesting solutions until the interview is complete.

FOUNDING ROUND HYPOTHESIS

These interviews are not intended to validate LifeBook.

They are intended to challenge our assumptions.

Our working hypothesis for the Founding Round is:

"LifeBook can solve a sufficiently important problem for a clearly defined group of people that they will willingly entrust it with meaningful parts of their lives, return repeatedly because it creates ongoing value, and ultimately support a sustainable business."

Customer discovery exists to prove or disprove this hypothesis.

Each interview should be evaluated against three questions:

- ▶ Is there a real, recurring problem — one that people experience often enough to matter?
- ▶ Is it important enough that someone would change their behaviour to solve it?
- ▶ Is trust the specific barrier that existing solutions have failed to address?

Critical discipline: *We are not looking for evidence that people like the idea. We are looking for evidence of a*

problem that is real, chronic, and unsolved. Confirmation is not progress. Disconfirmation is.

INTERVIEW PREPARATION CHECKLIST

Complete before every interview. Do not begin until all items are confirmed.

BEFORE CONTACTING THE PARTICIPANT

- ☐ Zoom meeting created and link confirmed
- ☐ Participant Guide sent to participant
- ☐ Participant has confirmed attendance
- ☐ Recording permission request prepared

BEFORE THE CALL BEGINS

- ☐ Zoom transcription enabled
- ☐ Recording destination verified (cloud or local)
- ☐ Backup recording method available if appropriate
- ☐ Interview Summary template open and ready
- ☐ Quiet environment confirmed
- ☐ Internet connection stable
- ☐ Microphone tested
- ☐ Camera confirmed
- ☐ Unnecessary applications closed
- ☐ Notifications silenced

Operational discipline: *Technical problems during an interview are distracting and undermine the psychological safety you have worked to create. Prevent them before the conversation begins.*

OPENING CONVERSATION — BEFORE RECORDING BEGINS

The opening is not part of the formal interview. Its purpose is to create psychological safety. A participant who feels genuinely comfortable will share more honestly than one who feels assessed.

Do not start recording until the conversation feels natural.

SUGGESTED FLOW

Admit the participant: *Welcome them warmly. Use their first name. Smile.*

Casual conversation: *Spend 2–3 minutes on something genuine and low-stakes — the weather, their location, how their day is going. This is not wasted time.*

Express genuine thanks: *"I really appreciate you making time for this. These conversations are genuinely valuable to us."*

Confirm the guide: *"Did you have a chance to look at the document I sent? Any questions before we get started?"*

Set expectations: *"There are no right or wrong answers here. I'm not looking for anything specific — I just want to understand your experience. If something doesn't apply to you, just say so. If a question seems strange, tell me."*

Give permission to go off-script: *"If something comes to mind that feels relevant, even if I haven't asked about it, please feel free to share it."*

Interviewer note: *Only begin recording when the conversation feels relaxed and the participant appears comfortable. Rushing to the formal interview is a mistake.*

BEGINNING THE RECORDING

Before starting the formal interview, establish the recording with the following verbal record.

RECORDING OPENING STATEMENT

State the date: *"Today is [date]."*

Interview number: *"This is Interview Number [number]."*

Introduce yourself: *"My name is [name], and I'm conducting this research on behalf of LifeBook."*

Confirm consent: *"[Participant's name], do you consent to this conversation being recorded for research purposes only?"*

Confirm right to stop: *"And do you understand that you may stop the interview or withdraw at any time without any obligation to explain why?"*

Wait for clear verbal confirmation of consent before proceeding. *Only after consent is confirmed should you read the formal Interview Introduction.*

INTERVIEW INTRODUCTION

Read this to the participant after recording has begun and consent has been confirmed:

"Thank you for taking the time to speak with me.

I'm researching how people preserve the important parts of their lives — memories, stories, photographs, documents, milestones, and family history.

There are no right or wrong answers. I'm interested in your experiences, your habits, and your frustrations.

I'd simply like to understand how you do things today."

SECTION 1 — UNDERSTANDING THE PERSON

1. Tell me a little about yourself.

- ▶ Family
- ▶ Career
- ▶ Interests
- ▶ Stage of life

2. If someone wanted to understand who you are fifty years from now, what would you hope they would know?

Interviewer note: *Listen carefully. Do not interrupt. This answer often reveals core values.*

SECTION 2 — CURRENT BEHAVIOUR

3. Where does your life live today?

Prompt only if necessary:

- ▶ Photos • Videos • Email • Documents • Paper files
- ▶ Journals • Social media • Text messages • Calendars
- ▶ Voice notes • Cloud storage

Ask: "What else?"

4. When was the last time you tried to find something meaningful from your past?

Examples:

- ▶ A photograph • A story • A document • A conversation • A memory

Follow-up:

- ▶ How long did it take?
- ▶ How successful were you?
- ▶ How did that make you feel?

Time context: Ask when this happened • How often does this happen • Has it happened more than once?
Timing and frequency distinguish chronic problems from isolated events.

5. Have you ever lost something important that you wish you still had?

Examples:

- ▶ Stories • Photos • Videos • Letters • Emails • Family history • Audio recordings

Follow-up:

- ▶ Why was it important?

Time context: Ask when this happened • How often does this happen • Has it happened more than once?
Timing and frequency distinguish chronic problems from isolated events.

SECTION 3 — EXISTING SOLUTIONS

6. Have you ever tried to organize your life or family history?

Examples:

- ▶ Scrapbooks • Journals • Evernote • Apple Notes • Google Drive
- ▶ Notion • Family tree software • Filing cabinets

Follow-up:

- ▶ What worked?
- ▶ What didn't?
- ▶ Why did you stop?

Time context: Ask when this happened · How often does this happen · Has it happened more than once?
Timing and frequency distinguish chronic problems from isolated events.

7. What frustrates you most about the way your memories and information are organized today?

Interviewer note: Do not suggest answers. Let them struggle. The struggle is valuable.

SECTION 3A — EVERYDAY MEMORY

This section explores ordinary behaviour — separate from milestone events or end-of-life reflection.

8. Tell me about the last time you wanted to remember something important — not because someone died or because it was a family milestone, but simply because it mattered to you.

Explore:

- ▶ What was it?
- ▶ Why was it important to you?
- ▶ How did you preserve it — or did you?
- ▶ Did you ever return to it?

Interviewer note: The goal is to understand everyday behaviour separately from emotionally exceptional events. If the participant reaches for legacy examples, gently redirect: "I'm curious about ordinary moments — things that just mattered to you personally."

Time context: Ask when this happened · How often does this happen · Has it happened more than once?
Timing and frequency distinguish chronic problems from isolated events.

SECTION 4 — FAMILY & LEGACY

9. Have you ever wished you had asked a parent, grandparent, or another family member more questions before it was too late?

If yes:

- ▶ Which questions?
- ▶ What do you wish you knew?

10. Is there anything you would like your children, grandchildren, or future family members to know about you that isn't written down anywhere?

Follow-up:

- ▶ Why hasn't it been preserved?

SECTION 5 — TRUST

11. If there were one place where your life's important stories and information could be safely preserved, what would you need to trust before using it?

Listen for — but do not introduce these ideas:

- ▶ Privacy
- ▶ Ownership
- ▶ Security
- ▶ Longevity
- ▶ Family access
- ▶ Cost
- ▶ Control

SECTION 6 — BEHAVIOUR & VALUE

12. Have you ever paid to preserve or organize something important?

Examples:

- ▶ Cloud storage • Photo books • Genealogy services • Family history subscriptions
- ▶ Scanning services • Professional photography • Backup systems

Follow-up:

- ▶ If yes — Why?
- ▶ If no — Why not?

13. Imagine your family opened a box fifty years from now that perfectly represented your life. What would you hope is inside?

Interviewer note: *This is intentionally emotional. Do not rush.*

CLOSING QUESTIONS

After all behavioural questions have been completed, ask:

"If there were a service designed to help preserve, organize, and connect the important parts of your life over time..."

- ▶ What would it absolutely have to do?
- ▶ What would make you refuse to use it?

CLOSING THE INTERVIEW

After the final question, follow this sequence carefully.

WHILE STILL RECORDING

Thank the participant: *"Thank you — this has been genuinely valuable. I really appreciate your time and your honesty."*

STOP RECORDING

Stop the recording before asking any off-the-record questions.

AFTER THE RECORDING HAS STOPPED

Off-the-record question: *"Is there anything else you think we should have asked? Anything you wanted to say that didn't quite fit the questions?"*

Interviewer note: *This question frequently produces the most candid and unexpected insights of the entire interview. Give it space.*

Handling off-the-record responses

- ▶ This response will not appear in the recording or Zoom transcript.
- ▶ If the participant shares a material insight, summarize it in your own words in the Interview Summary section. Do not quote verbatim without their explicit permission.
- ▶ Handle any sensitive remarks with care and discretion.
- ▶ The participant's decision to speak off the record is final — do not press or challenge it.

If the participant asks about LifeBook or future involvement:

Answer honestly and briefly. Do not transition into a pitch. If there is genuine interest in continuing the conversation, offer to arrange a separate follow-up discussion at another time. Maintain the clear separation between customer discovery and fundraising.

INTERVIEW SUMMARY — COMPLETED BY INTERVIEWER

Complete this form immediately after each interview, while the conversation is still fresh.

Interview Number	
Date	
Participant	
Age Range	
Occupation	
Family Status	
Key Problems Observed (Top three)	
Existing Solutions Used	

Biggest Frustration (In their own words)	
Strongest Emotional Moment	
Most Generative Question	
Unexpected Insights (What surprised us?)	
Direct Quotes (Three memorable quotations)	
Behavioural Evidence (Actions taken — not intentions)	
Willingness to Pay (Did they already spend? Would they again?)	
Confidence Rating (Problem significance, 1-10)	
Product Opportunities (Observations only —	

no invented solutions)

QUANTITATIVE ASSESSMENT

Rate each dimension based on your overall impression of the interview. This is a pattern-detection tool across 20–30 interviews — not a replacement for qualitative observation.

DIMENSION	SCALE	SCORE / RATING
Emotional Response	1 – 10	
Problem Severity	1 – 10	
Current Frustration	1 – 10	
Existing Workaround	<i>Strong / Moderate / Weak / None</i>	
Trust Sensitivity	1 – 10	
Likelihood of Behaviour Change	1 – 10	
Likelihood of Paying	<i>Yes / Maybe / No</i>	

ASSUMPTIONS CHALLENGED

Record how this interview changed your thinking. We are looking for learning, not confirmation.

Before this interview
we believed...

After this interview
we believe...

Confidence Level (1–
10, with reason)

Follow-up Questions
Generated

IMMEDIATELY AFTER THE INTERVIEW

Before doing anything else — before responding to messages, before discussing the interview with colleagues — complete the following:

POST-INTERVIEW CHECKLIST

- ☐ Interview Summary completed
- ☐ Quantitative Assessment completed
- ☐ Assumptions Challenged completed
- ☐ Immediate impressions recorded while memory is fresh
- ☐ Recording saved and confirmed
- ☐ Transcript saved and confirmed
- ☐ Files named consistently

File naming convention:

Interview_007_Smith_2026-07-18

[Interview_] [Number] [Participant surname] [YYYY-MM-DD]

Use this format for recordings, transcripts, and summaries. Consistent naming prevents lost files and allows patterns to be identified across the full interview set.

IMMEDIATE REFLECTION

Complete before reviewing the transcript or discussing the interview with others. This section is for the interviewer — not to evaluate the participant.

What surprised you
most about this
conversation?

Which assumption

**feels weakest after
this interview?**

**Which question
worked especially
well — and why?**

**Which question
should be
reconsidered or
improved?**

**What should we test
or probe more deeply
in the next interview?**

INTERVIEW RULES

1. Speak less than 20% of the time.
2. Never pitch LifeBook during the interview.
3. Ask a follow-up question whenever someone says "I wish..."
4. Focus on what people have done — not what they think they might do.
5. Record exact phrases whenever possible.
6. Every interview should challenge at least one assumption.
7. If an interview confirms everything you already believed, assume you did not ask enough difficult questions.

THE THREE INTERVIEW CATEGORIES

Our plan is not to interview only strangers. We will interview three distinct categories of participants:

Category 1 — People Who Know You Well

They will be brutally honest about your assumptions. Their familiarity is an asset, not a bias to avoid.

Category 2 — People Who Have Never Heard of LifeBook

Essential for eliminating confirmation bias. These conversations will surface problems you have not yet imagined.

Category 3 — Domain Experts

Estate lawyers, grief counsellors, family historians, therapists, genealogists, professional organizers, archivists. They see these problems every day and often recognize patterns that individual users cannot.

Target: 30 interviews — 10 from each category.

At that scale, the output is not anecdotes. It is the beginning of an evidence base.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

This interview process is successful when, after 20–30 interviews, we can answer the following questions with evidence — not assumptions:

- ▶ Who experiences the greatest pain?
- ▶ What triggers that pain?
- ▶ How do they currently solve it?
- ▶ Why are current solutions inadequate?
- ▶ Which problem is urgent enough to change behaviour?

- ▶ Which feature would provide immediate value?
- ▶ What would people willingly pay for?
- ▶ What must LifeBook do to earn trust from day one?

Every interview that challenges one of our existing assumptions is a success. Every interview that only confirms what we already believe is a missed opportunity.